

False Memory Word List Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 15-20 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	15-20 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	false-memory-word-list

Big idea: Coherence can produce confident false memory.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect False Memory Word List Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

False Memory Word List Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A word list around sleep that omits the word 'sleep'. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
False Memory Word List Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A second list around sweet foods that omits 'candy' or 'sugar'. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
False Memory Word List Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A recall sheet separating remembered words from inferred words. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Coherence can produce confident false memory.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting False Memory Word List Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from False Memory Word List Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Does a coherent story make a belief feel more true?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A word list around sleep that omits the word 'sleep'.
- A second list around sweet foods that omits 'candy' or 'sugar'.
- A recall sheet separating remembered words from inferred words.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and the Knower.

Activity Steps

1. Read the word list aloud once.
2. Students complete a distractor task for one minute.
3. Ask which words they remember. Include the lure word "sleep" on a recognition list.
4. Count how many students confidently remember the lure.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Does a coherent story make a belief feel more true?
- What is the difference between remembering and inferring?
- What does this suggest about legal testimony, history and personal identity?

Knowledge Questions

- Does a coherent story make a belief feel more true?
- What is the difference between remembering and inferring?
- What does this suggest about legal testimony, history and personal identity?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a word list around sleep that omits the word 'sleep'. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...